

Model Answer
UHB (Social Psychology)

Q1. Define group and explain any 2 theories of group antagonism (4 marks). Outline atleast 2 strategies to reduce group antagonism (3 marks).

Answer:

Group may be defined as two or more people, in face-to-face interaction, each aware of their group membership and interdependence, as they strive to achieve their goals.

OR

Two or more interdependent individuals who influence one another through social interactions that commonly include structures involving roles and norms, a degree of cohesiveness, and shared goals.

Any of the following mentioned theories could be opted for the answer:

1) Realistic Group Conflict Theory:

- Group antagonism is inevitable since there is real competition between groups on power and resources.
- Robbers cave experiment (Sherif & Sherif, 1954) - (may explain in few lines)
- Real deprivation vs. relative deprivation (may mention few points of the differences)

2) Authoritarian Personality Theory:

- Theodore Adorno (1940) believed that people develop an authoritarian personality because of the upbringing they had as a child.
- This theory suggests that prejudice is associated with a particular personality type.

- Authoritarian personalities have a number of characteristics. They are very concerned with status and upholding convention; they are very conformist; they tend to be very obsequious towards people they see as having a higher status than them but treat those 'below' them with contempt and they are suspicious of and hostile towards those they see as different.
- If their parents are overly strict and punitive and show little love, the child grows up harbouring resentment and hostility towards their parents. This hostility gets directed towards members of minority groups through a process of displacement.

3) Social Identity Theory (Tajfel, 1982): This theory assumes that -

- People categorize the entire world into ingroup and outgroup
- People derive a sense of self-esteem from their social identity of an ingroup.
- People's self-concepts partly depend on how they evaluate their ingroup as compared to the outgroups.

Added Note: May or may not mention the below mentioned points

- **Assumed similarity:** perception that members of the in-group share their attitudes and values.
- **Out-group homogeneity effect:** perception that members of the outgroup are more similar to each other than members of the in-group to each other.
- **In-group favouritism:** the tendency to give more favourable evaluations and greater rewards to members of one's in-group as compared to members of out-groups

4) Sense of group position theory (Bobo, 1999):

- **Dominant groups' sense of group position is derived from:**

- A belief in the superiority of the dominant group
- Perceptions of members of the subordinate group as alien and different
- Proprietary claims over superior resources
- feelings of threat from subordinate groups coveting superior resources

5) **Social Dominance Theory (Sidanius and Pratto, 1999):**

- Desire to have one's in-group in a position of dominance or superiority to out-groups.
High social dominance orientation is correlated with higher levels of prejudice.
- Two mechanisms through which dominant groups maintain their position (may only mention the mechanisms):
 - **Benevolent paternalism:** affectionate and benevolent treatment towards the subordinate group members, e.g., "in the manner of a father dealing with his children"
 - **Legitimizing myth:** an ideology that justifies inequalities in the current social hierarchy

Two strategies to reduce group antagonism

1. **Contact theory:** Prejudice against a social group can be reduced by appropriate contact with individuals from that group.

- Conditions:
 - Co-operative interdependence
 - Equal status among individuals
 - Frequent contact among members
 - Support from institutions

- 2. Recategorization:** Large and inclusive group categories in order to defuse conflict among smaller groups.

Mark Distribution for question 1:

- Definition of group (1 mark)
- Naming the theory and explanation. (1.5 marks each theory)
- Any two strategies of prejudice mitigation (1.5 mark per strategy)

Note : Definition of group should include all the important characteristics of group. The explanation of group antagonism theories should entail a brief description of the theories and underlying mechanisms. Similarly prejudice strategies must also entail the underlying mechanisms.

Q2. Define attitude. With the help of any 2 theories explain the process of attitude formation.
(5.5 marks)

Answer:

Attitude is a predisposition or a tendency to respond positively or negatively toward a certain idea, object, person, or situation. It is structured along three dimensions: cognitive (perceptions and beliefs), affective (feelings), and behavioral (actions).

Either of the following theories can be opted for the answer:

- 1) Classical conditioning:** It refers to the process of an automatic, conditioned response

that is paired with a specific stimulus.

- **Explanation of the underlying mechanisms with example :**

- positive stimuli (e.g., attractive
- models) are repeatedly paired with the product, with the aim being to directly transfer the
- affect felt toward them to the brand.

2. **Operant conditioning:** It is a learning process in which voluntary behaviors are modified by association with the addition (or removal) of reward or aversive stimuli.

- **Explanation of the underlying mechanisms with example:**

- law of effect i.e., learner's action is instrumental in producing change in the environment that increases the likelihood of a behaviour, e.g., food 'reinforces' the key pressing behaviour among rats.

3. **Theory of cognitive consistency:** A theory addressing the need to maintain consistency among our feelings and beliefs about what goes together.

- Three evaluations:

- a. The first person's evaluation of the other person
- b. The first person's evaluation of the attitude object
- c. The other person's evaluation of the attitude object

4. **Cognitive dissonance theory:** A theory of attitude change proposing that if inconsistency

exists among our attitudes, or between our attitudes and our behavior, we experience an unpleasant state of arousal called cognitive dissonance, which we will be motivated to reduce or eliminate.

5. Counterattitudinal Behaviour

- Indulging in behaviour that is inconsistent with one's own attitude.
- We cannot really always change our actions, so we often change our beliefs.
- Joining social sciences to help the society and then realising that not much can be done there.
- Attitude-discrepant behaviour: joining a job to get paid, rather than to do social work.

Marks Distribution for question two:

- Definition of attitude (0.5 marks)
- Naming the theory and explanation. (2.5 marks each theory)

Note : The explanation of theories should entail a brief description of the theories and a detailed description of the underlying mechanisms through which attitude is formed.

